

CLICKING to Connect

Urban India has discovered social networking but not Indianised it. The next step may be going regional.

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- Sixdegrees.com was the world's first social networking site. Created in 1997, it was shut down in 2000.
- The average Facebook user has 217 friends.
- Orkut is most popular in Brazil with 50 per cent of those using networking sites hooked to it. In India, 15 per cent use Orkut.

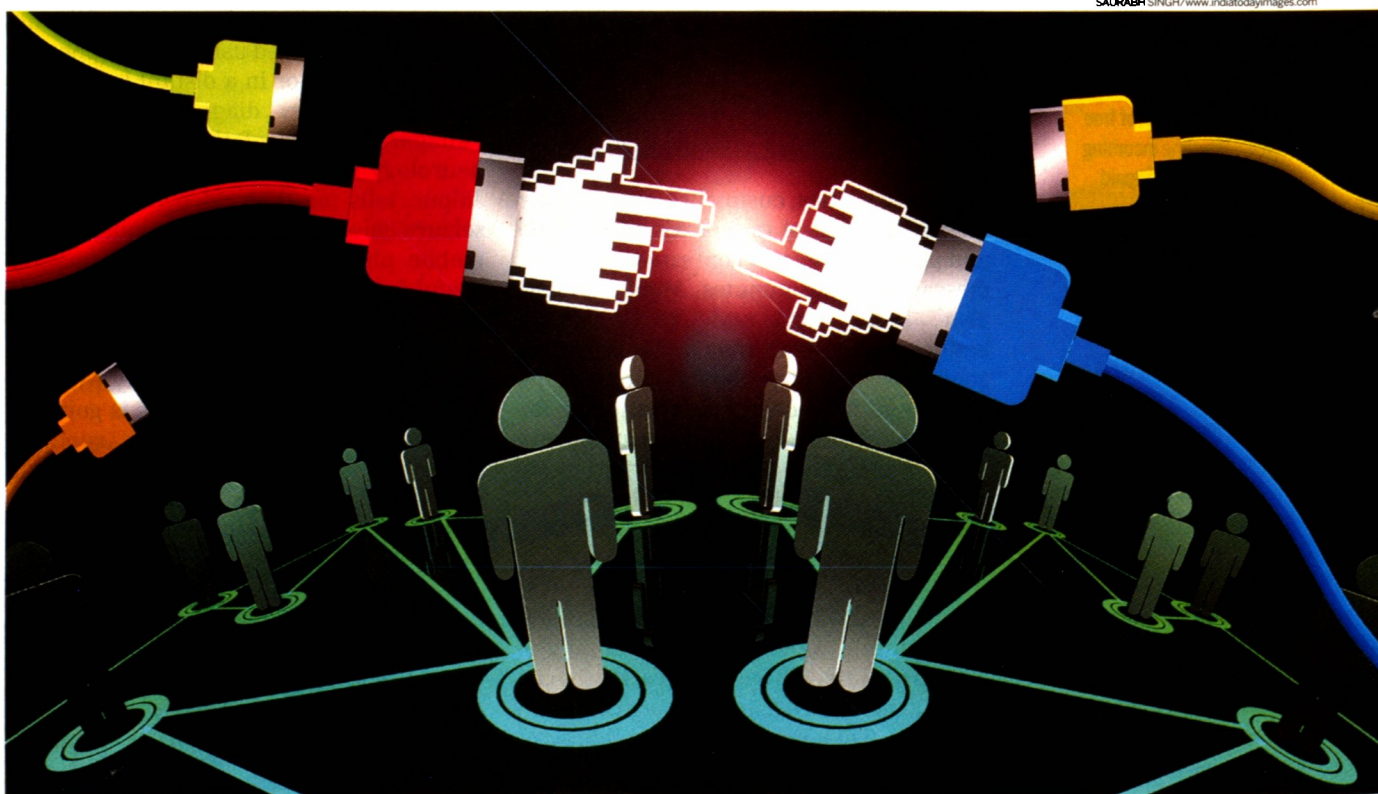
By Shiv Visvanathan |

Most of us over 40 are Rip Van Winkles. We do not need to go to sleep for new worlds to be born. Continents are being invented next door to us. Visually and acoustically, the world is changing and there are even new words for change. From the stem cell to Facebook, you realise new kinds of languages; a new technological *patois* is epidemic. In an old-fashioned way, you take out your book and your tape and seek to create an ethnography of this world, exploring similarity and difference and then discover that you can

search for hits in MySpace.

Take social networking. As an old fashioned sociologist, one would think it dealt with the excitement around social capital, trust, about entrepreneurship that leverages ties and old affinities. Then you realise that is old hat. Elinor Ostrom has already received the Nobel Prize for it and Robert Putnam and Partha Dasgupta are already commemorative stamps. The term refers not to old worlds where you leverage skills but new techno spaces where you have to invent the social basis of relationships.

Words like Zoho, Fropper, Big Adda and Minglebox sound like cafes for a quaint evening rather than names for new portals.



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